

ASSIGNMENT INSTRUCTIONS “EXPLORING WESTERN PHILOSOPHY”

Sem 1 2026/27, Dr. Markus Heidingsfelder

1. Essay Writing Instructions

This is an **in-class, 45-minute essay**. It is not a test of how many facts, quotations, or famous names you can reproduce. It is a test of whether you can formulate a philosophical problem, reconstruct an argument fairly, and make a careful comparison across intellectual traditions. It also serves as a preparation for the final exam (no AI use in the final exam though).

The task

Write a short, focused philosophical essay in response to the question provided in class. You may be asked to discuss a thinker, a concept, a passage, or a philosophical problem—for example, myth, justice, knowledge, freedom, selfhood, virtue, nature, reason, political order, beauty, or truth.

Do not merely summarize: “Aristotle believed X,” “Descartes said Y,” or “Kant argued Z.” Use the thinker or concept to answer a question.

Every essay must include a meaningful relation between **a Western thinker, text, or concept** and **China or another Asian intellectual tradition, context, or problem**. This is not an invitation to reduce either side to a stereotype. “The West values the individual; Asia values harmony” is not an argument. Make one precise comparison: identify a shared problem, a difference in conceptual framing, a tension, a possible misunderstanding, or a limit of one framework when seen from the other.

The goal is not to declare a winner. It is to make the philosophical question more visible.

A workable structure

You do not need headings, but a strong short essay usually does the following:

1. **State a claim early.** Answer the question in one or two sentences. Give the reader a thesis, not merely a topic.
2. **Explain one argument accurately.** Define the key term or distinction and show how the argument works. Use a course text, lecture, or specific example.
3. **Relate it to China/Asia.** Compare carefully. Ask what becomes clearer, more complicated, or less convincing when the question crosses traditions or contexts.
4. **Conclude with a consequence.** Explain what the comparison changes in the original question.

A short essay does not need to cover everything. One clear argument is better than a rushed tour of five philosophers.

Using AI

AI tools are **permitted** in this course. You may use them to brainstorm questions, test an outline, clarify a term, generate counterarguments, improve grammar, or help locate possible connections.

Ask an LLM for an interpretation of Plato, Kant, or Nietzsche. Identify what it gets right. Find its simplifications and inherited categories. Test whether its “comparison” relies on clichés. Compare its translation choices with the original terms. Rewrite its response so that it becomes more precise, historically grounded, and philosophically defensible – but most of all: “more you”.

The point is not to prove that humans are superior to machines. It is to understand that the technological environment has changed what counts as meaningful evidence of learning. OECD research similarly warns that unguided outsourcing to generative AI can improve performance without producing learning gains.

One especially useful use of AI is **critical revision**. Ask it to identify general, civilizational, or inherited language in a draft—for example, phrases such as “Western individualism,” “Asian harmony,” “Chinese collectivism,” or “Eastern wisdom.” Then decide for yourself whether the phrase is defensible, what history and implication it carries, and which more precise formulation the evidence supports. Do not let AI replace one cliché with another.

Be especially careful when translating answers from Chinese-language systems, including DeepSeek, into English. Translation does not simply transfer neutral content between languages. It selects terms, imports conceptual associations, and can make categories look more familiar, more Western, more coherent, or more oppositional than they are in the original. When possible, retain key terms in Chinese, compare more than one translation, and explain rather than silently flatten a difficult concept.

But this is an in-class assignment. Your submitted essay must be your own live intellectual work: your selection of the problem, your argument, your examples, and your wording as written during the 45 minutes. Do not copy an AI-generated answer, do not submit pre-written text, and do not use AI as a substitute for reading, thinking, or making distinctions.

Use AI as a conversation partner, not as a ghostwriter. If you use AI, add a disclosure at the end of your essay.

What assessment now means

When an LLM can help produce fluent prose, education cannot assess writing only by asking whether a student has produced a polished text. The relevant question becomes: **What can the student do with a text whose production may have involved AI?**

This course therefore assesses your capacity to make distinctions in relation to texts: to observe, select, contextualise, criticise, compare, reject, and connect. You may receive a well-phrased answer from an AI system. Your task is to ask: What does it assume? Which concepts does it translate too quickly? What does it omit? Where is it vague? What source, example, or counterargument changes it?

This is not an attempt to make education “more human” by opposing it to machines. It acknowledges that the technological environment has changed the conditions under which writing can function as evidence of learning. The essay remains valuable—not as proof that no tool was used, but as evidence that you can turn available language into a considered philosophical argument.

What will be assessed

- **Argument:** Does the essay make a clear, defensible claim?
- **Accuracy:** Does it represent the thinker, concept, or text fairly?
- **Philosophical depth:** Does it examine assumptions, distinctions, tensions, or consequences rather than merely report information?
- **China/Asia relation:** Is the comparison specific, relevant, and non-stereotypical?
- **AI literacy:** If AI is used, does the essay show critical selection rather than unexamined dependence?
- **Clarity:** Is the essay organized, readable, and focused within the time limit?

Before you submit

Ask yourself:

- Have I answered a question, rather than only described a thinker?
- Have I explained at least one key concept accurately?
- Have I related the topic meaningfully to China or Asia?
- Have I avoided treating “the West,” “China,” or “Asia” as fixed, uniform blocks?
- If I used AI, did I test, revise, or reject its wording rather than merely reproduce it?
- Does my final sentence say what the comparison has taught us?

Write boldly, but make distinctions. Philosophy begins when an obvious answer becomes questionable.

Rubrics

Criterion	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Development	Poor / Incomplete
Thesis and argument	Presents a clear, original, and defensible thesis immediately. Develops a coherent argument with strong logical movement and a meaningful conclusion.	Presents a clear thesis and mostly coherent argument. Conclusion follows from the discussion.	Has a recognizable main point, but the argument may be general, uneven, or only partly developed.	Main point is vague, descriptive, contradictory, or difficult to locate.	No thesis or argument; response is off-topic, fragmentary, or largely copied/unsupported.
Understanding of philosophy	Explains the thinker, text, or concept accurately and precisely. Defines key terms and reconstructs an argument rather than merely reporting opinions.	Explains the central idea accurately, with minor simplifications or omissions.	Shows basic understanding but relies on broad summary, imprecise terms, or unexamined claims.	Contains significant confusion, unsupported assertions, or major oversimplifications.	Misrepresents the thinker or concept substantially, or shows no meaningful engagement with course material.
Critical reflection	Identifies assumptions, tensions, blind spots, consequences, or objections with nuance. Makes distinctions rather than repeating familiar formulas.	Includes a relevant critical question or objection and develops it reasonably well.	Offers some evaluation, but it may be predictable, brief, or insufficiently connected to the argument.	Criticism is largely asserted, moralistic, or disconnected from the philosophical discussion.	No critical reflection; merely lists facts, quotations, or opinions.
China / Asia relation	Builds a precise, relevant, and non-stereotypical relation to China or Asia. The comparison changes or deepens the original philosophical question.	Makes a relevant comparison with some specificity; avoids major stereotypes.	Includes the required relation, but it remains brief, generic, or loosely connected.	Uses broad civilizational claims—for example, “the West is individualistic; Asia is harmonious”—without evidence or analysis.	Omits China/Asia entirely, or treats it as decorative, inaccurate, or stereotypical.
Use of evidence and examples	Uses course texts, concepts, quotations, or concrete examples selectively and effectively. Evidence strengthens the argument.	Uses relevant evidence or examples appropriately, though not always fully integrated.	Uses at least one relevant example, but evidence may be thin, vague, or only loosely explained.	Makes claims without adequate evidence; examples are inaccurate or irrelevant.	No usable evidence, or material is fabricated, plagiarized, or unrelated.
Clarity and organisation	Highly readable, focused, and well structured despite the time limit. Each paragraph advances the argument.	Clear and organized overall; occasional awkwardness or repetition does not obstruct meaning.	Understandable but unevenly organized, repetitive, or rushed.	Difficult to follow because of unclear structure, imprecise language, or major writing problems.	Largely unintelligible, excessively incomplete, or not submitted in an assessable form.
Critical use of AI	If AI is used, the student clearly selects, revises, contextualises, verifies, or rejects AI output. AI use is disclosed briefly and supports independent thinking.	AI use, if any, is disclosed and mostly used critically; the student’s own argument remains clear.	AI disclosure is present, but critical engagement is limited or unclear.	AI use appears unexamined, overly dependent, or inadequately disclosed.	Undisclosed AI-generated or pre-written text is submitted as independent in-class work; academic-integrity procedures may apply.

2. Presentation Instructions

Your group will not simply present “**Aristotle,**” “**Descartes,**” or “**Kant.**” Your task is to use one philosopher, text, concept, or controversy as an entry point for exploration: reconstruct an argument, place it in its historical setting, and ask what it makes visible—and what it may leave invisible.

Format and timing

- **Group size:** 8 students
- **Individual speaking time:** 5 minutes per student
- **Total session time:** 40 minutes
- **Presentation:** approximately 35 minutes
- **Q&A:** approximately 5 minutes

Every student must have a clearly identifiable, substantive role. Divide the material so that the presentation has one coherent argument rather than eight unrelated mini-talks.

Your intellectual task

A good presentation does more than summarize a philosopher’s life or list their ideas. It should answer a focused question and include the following elements:

- **The philosophical problem:** What question is at stake? For example: What is justice? What can we know? What is freedom? What is a self? What is a good life?
- **The argument:** What is the thinker’s answer, and how does the argument work? Explain key concepts accurately and use at least one short passage or concrete example.
- **The historical setting:** Why did this question matter at that moment? What political, religious, scientific, economic, or social conditions shaped the discussion?
- **The critical question:** What assumptions does the argument make? What does it foreground, and what might it overlook—such as gender, class, empire, religion, race, ecology, embodiment, technology, or non-European intellectual traditions?
- **The present connection:** Why is this philosopher or problem still worth discussing? Do not force a simplistic modern “application”; make the connection precise.

Treat “Western” not as a fixed essence, but as a historically changing and contested name for traditions, institutions, texts, and self-descriptions. You may use a careful comparison with another philosophical tradition when it genuinely clarifies the issue. Do not add a “non-Western comparison” merely as decoration.

Slides

Slides are a **group product**. They must be visually and conceptually homogeneous: one design, one citation style, one terminology, one line of argument. The slide grade is the same for every member of the group.

- Use slides to support attention, not to replace speaking.
- Keep text concise: key terms, quotations, diagrams, images, dates, and questions work better than paragraphs.
- Cite quotations, images, and external ideas directly on the relevant slide.
- Include a final slide with the sources used.
- Do not read from slides. Reading a prepared essay aloud is also not a presentation.

Delivery and discussion

Present freely, clearly, and interactively. You may use brief notes on cards, but maintain eye contact and speak to the room. Explain terms before relying on them. Invite the audience into the philosophical problem through a question, example, short thought experiment, or disagreement.

The final Q&A is part of the presentation. All group members must be ready to answer questions, clarify claims, and respond respectfully to disagreement. Free speech in this course means that strong arguments, objections, and disagreement are welcome; it also means representing texts and other participants fairly.

Assessment

Individual grade — based on each student's 5-minute contribution:

- Accuracy and clarity of explanation
- Quality of argument and critical reflection
- Effective use of evidence, examples, and sources
- Speaking, engagement, and response in Q&A

Shared slide grade — identical for all group members:

- Coherence of the overall presentation
- Homogeneous design and clear structure
- Appropriate, accurate citation and source use
- Slides that support rather than duplicate the spoken presentation

Practical checklist

Before presenting, make sure that your group can answer:

- What is our guiding question—in one sentence?
- What is the philosopher's central argument?
- What is at least one serious objection or blind spot?
- Why does the question matter now?
- Does every student speak for about 5 minutes?
- Do our slides look and sound as if one group made them?

Rubrics

Criterion	Excellent	Good	Satisfactory	Needs Development	Poor / Incomplete
Philosophical accuracy	Thinkers, texts, concepts, and arguments are explained precisely. Key distinctions are defined and claims are represented fairly.	Central material is accurate, with only minor omissions or simplifications.	Basic understanding is visible, but the presentation relies too heavily on summary or imprecise terms.	Significant confusion, unsupported claims, or oversimplifications weaken the presentation.	Material is substantially misrepresented or shows no meaningful engagement with course content.
Critical reflection	Identifies assumptions, tensions, blind spots, objections, and consequences with nuance. Makes distinctions rather than repeating familiar formulas.	Includes relevant critical questions or objections and develops them reasonably well.	Offers some evaluation, but it may be predictable, brief, or loosely connected to the argument.	Criticism is generic, moralistic, asserted without argument, or disconnected from the topic.	No critical reflection; the presentation merely lists facts, quotations, or opinions.
China / Asia relation	Builds a precise, relevant, and non-stereotypical relation to China or Asia that changes or deepens the original philosophical problem.	Makes a clear and relevant comparison, with some specificity and appropriate caution.	Includes the required comparison, but it remains brief, generic, or weakly connected.	Relies on unsupported civilizational formulas, such as "the West is individualistic" or "Asia values harmony."	Omits China/Asia entirely, or treats it inaccurately, decoratively, or stereotypically.
Evidence, examples, and citations	Uses course texts, concepts, quotations, images, and concrete examples selectively and effectively. Sources are accurate and clearly cited.	Uses relevant evidence and sources appropriately, with only minor gaps in integration or citation.	Includes some relevant evidence, but sources may be thin, vague, or inconsistently cited.	Makes broad claims without adequate evidence; sources are unclear, inaccurate, or poorly integrated.	Evidence is absent, fabricated, plagiarized, or unrelated to the presentation.
Speaking and audience engagement	Speakers present freely, clearly, and confidently; explain rather than read; use notes only as support; maintain eye contact; and invite intellectual participation.	Speaking is clear and mostly free, with occasional dependence on notes or slides.	Generally understandable, but noticeably read, rushed, unevenly paced, or low in audience engagement.	Difficult to follow because of extensive reading, unclear delivery, weak preparation, or poor time management.	Speakers read entirely from slides or scripts, do not speak meaningfully, or disregard the time allocation.
Q&A and response to disagreement	Group members respond thoughtfully, accurately, and respectfully; they can clarify, qualify, or revise claims when challenged.	Responds appropriately to questions and shows command of the main topic.	Participates when prompted, but answers may be brief, uncertain, or only partly relevant.	Avoids participation or cannot explain central claims beyond prepared remarks.	Does not participate in Q&A or responds dismissively, inaccurately, or inappropriately.
Slides: design and coherence	Slides are visually homogeneous, readable, restrained, and professional. One design, terminology, citation style, and visual logic runs through the group work.	Slides are clear and mostly consistent, with minor design or terminology inconsistencies.	Slides are usable but occasionally crowded, uneven, visually inconsistent, or difficult to read.	Slides are text-heavy, inconsistent, poorly organized, or distract from the presentation.	Slides are absent, illegible, copied without adaptation, or seriously undermine the presentation.
Slides: function	Slides support attention and argument through key terms, short quotations, diagrams, images, dates, and concise sources. They are never read aloud.	Slides generally support the presentation and use material appropriately.	Slides include relevant information but may repeat the speech, contain too much text, or cite inconsistently.	Slides function as scripts, lack adequate references, or contain unverified claims.	Slides are used as a substitute for presenting or contain fabricated/plagiarized content.
Group coordination and timing	Transitions are smooth; the presentation feels like one collective intellectual and visual argument; timing is excellent; all members are prepared.	Group is well coordinated, with only minor timing or transition problems.	Basic coordination is visible, but sections may feel like separate mini-talks or run unevenly.	Major coordination, transition, or timing problems disrupt the presentation.	No meaningful group coordination; presentation collapses into disconnected or unfinished parts.